reassurance, pivoting the reply by sharing a fourth-wicket stand of 173 with Jonny Bairstow.

We weren't going to mess it up. We needed only twelve overs to wrap up a win, by an innings and seventy-eight, on the third morning. It was grey overhead, but the celebrations were colourful, almost karmic. Farby ensured that due deference was paid to Peter Moores. Lehmann, who had incited Australian crowds in 2013 by hoping Broady would be sent home 'crying', had to watch him pick up the most obvious man of the match award imaginable.

I was very emotional in a post-match interview with Michael Atherton and was in contemplative mood during a press conference staged in a claustrophobic, overheated squash court. I felt for Michael Clarke, whose captaincy had ended tearfully, in the same setting, but I also carried the spirit of those who had been alongside me over the previous two years.

Without being selfish, this felt like *my* team. The scenes, walking round the ground, signing autographs and posing for selfies three hours after the match, were the manifestation of a long-held idea. These guys had bought into the principle of reconnection. They were what I envisaged, when I spoke of us being England players, 24/7.

Changing an image is not a whim of administrators, or PR flim-flam merchants. It comes from the hearts of those who prove themselves under competitive pressure. We might have been loved as the world number one team, who beat all-comers during a heady spell, but it was cupboard love. The mood soon shifted when it was our turn to be hammered.

We weren't faultless, but on that day at Trent Bridge we illustrated a truth that had needed time to be taken on board. This was an accessible England team; we were bigger than the result, but not bigger than the game of cricket. We might not have played at our best consistently, but we played with gratitude. We were desperate to make our mark and didn't allow egos to get in the way.

The changing room was mobbed. Rooty conducted a TV interview sitting on a table, wearing a rubber Einstein facemask, and doing Bob Willis impressions. People saw our human side. We were not robots, after all. We were genuine. I felt trusted as a leader, despite getting so many things wrong in the previous couple of years, and trusted the group in return. I looked around and saw individuals who had given something of themselves.